Wood is an increasingly expensive material and for the woodturner, this ought to mean getting the most out of the stock we purchase. Like most of you I am often guilty of saving offcuts and odd scraps for that day when 'they'll come in handy'. The truth is, of course, that this day rarely arrives and we can become buried under piles of oddments, none of which we can bring ourselves to reclassify as firewood. Considering the escalating cost of the material, this is probably no bad thing, but we do need to make an effort to use these choice off-cuts unless we are willing to sacrifice substantial storage space.

When I was asked to do a triptych as a project, I decided that this was an ideal opportunity to use at least one of these offcuts. I had a length of oak (*Quercus robur*) 1195 x 75 x 25mm, that was left after a job. It was really only fit for finials, or pen blanks: as oak is not ideal for the former and would require some time to machine for the latter, I decided to use it to make the triptych wall piece.

'Triptych' simply means 'three parts', and is usually used when describing three-part art or religious icons. Historically, the three parts would have been hinged, creating a central panel and two wings. In this instance, my intention was not to hinge them, but that isn't to say that you couldn't decide otherwise; as ever, this project should be looked upon as a spring board for your own imagination and experimentation. Using oddments of wood in this way can not only make some space in your storage bins, it can lead you down new and exciting pathways in your turning.

HEALTH AND SAFETY

The nature of this project, and the turning involved, means that it has perhaps a greater than usual potential for danger, so extreme care needs to be taken. This project ought not to be attempted by the novice turner without experienced supervision.

- Is the wood dangerously degraded, weak, or worm damaged?
- Is the weight and size of the workpiece within the capabilities of your lathe?
- Can you adequately and safely mount the workpiece?
- Can you accommodate or counteract any imbalance in the workpiece?
- Is the lathe power supply accessible if needed in an emergency?
- Do you have appropriately-rated PPE? Wear a compliant full-face safety visor!

Consider all of the above points, taking any necessary actions arising and erring on the side of safety. The lathe should be set to a slower speed than you might usually use for a disc of the same diameter. Providing you keep your fingers on your side of the tool rest there should be no danger of an accident. Before you begin turning, ensure that your tools are sharp, that the workpiece doesn't foul, and that the tool rest is securely locked down.

Remembering these golden rules should keep you safe in such turning projects.

1 Having selected a suitable piece of wood, you need to cut it in to three equal length pieces. When placed side-by-side, the diagonal measurement should be safely within the swing of your lathe. Depending on your personal aesthetic preferences you may wish to prepare these pieces by planing and/or abrading the pieces prior to turning. My personal preference is to leave them in the rough-cut state as the saw cuts can add interesting texture. They can always be cleaned up later if you change your mind. Once you have your three component parts, prepare them for mounting on the lathe as a single plank. There are several options for this. If your boards are small, light and fairly flat, you might consider batons screwed across the back

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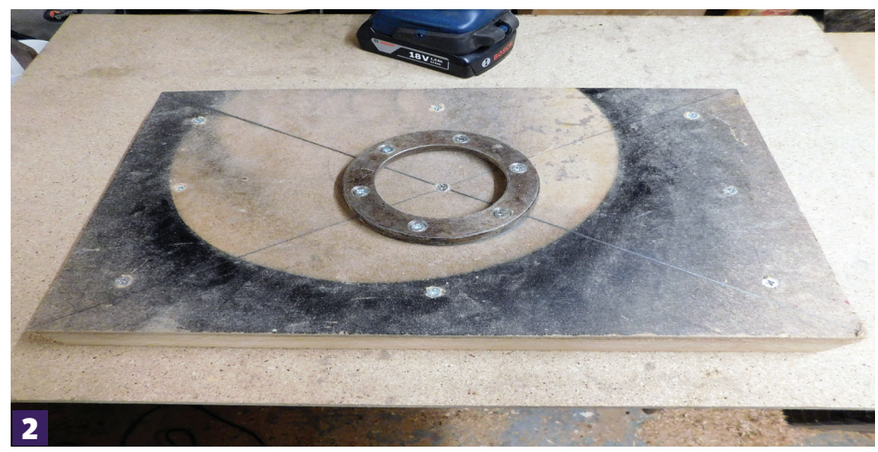
2 A safer method is to set the three boards onto a backboard and secure each with three double helix woodscrews to half the depth of the boards. Once the board is fixed, mark across the corners to find the centre. Using a compass, scribe a circle to match a faceplate ring to fit your scroll chuck. Secure the faceplate ring with double helix woodscrews. Ensure the screws are deep enough to make for a secure hold, but be aware of the depth to avoid cutting through to them from the face side of the completed workpiece. You might also consider altering the spacing or position of the boards to create different effects after turning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